

Dell Inspiron 1100

Inspired blue box

This metallic blue and silver-grey finished laptop from Dell comes second in the looks department, only because it was outdone by the beautiful looking HP laptops. Though the rounded contours spell panache, the design looks boxy. The build-quality is excellent, and it doesn't squeak when you press hard on it.

The Inspiron has a comfortable keyboard with a lot of space to rest your palms. The touchpad is small, but sensitive, and the large buttons are a boon, but lack tactile feedback.

Connectors that you'll use pretty often are placed at the back, and could cause some irritation as you'd have to change the laptop's, or your own position everytime you want to connect a USB device. The integrated speakers are simply useless.

In terms of features, this laptop was quite disappointing, and lacked serial and parallel connectors—the fact that it only provides two USB ports doesn't make up for it. It lost miserably to the HP Compaq models in this respect.

When it comes to performance, the Inspiron is no couch-potato. Its desktop processor has enough fire power to run most office applications smoothly. A point to remember is that the Inspiron 1100 base-model ships with 128 MB of RAM, but you can specifically ask for 256 MB, for an additional price; that's what we did. If you're going to buy this laptop, we strongly suggest the RAM upgrade for acceptable performance with Windows XP. The thermodynamics of this laptop are superb—even after running continuously for a day, the external surface was as cool as a cucumber.

Priced at Rs 79,969, the Inspiron 1100 is a good deal, but not if you're on the lookout for a feature rich laptop.



Dell Inspiron 1100	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 79,769
+ Great build quality and looks
- Low on features

HP Compaq nx9000

A workhorse

The HP Compaq nx9000 has a metallic jet-black body, with attractive blue neon lights working as system status indicators. The keyboard is well spaced, with keys providing the right amount of tactile feel. It has a digital scroll that lets you go through a document simply by moving your finger over the area. Placed just above the touchpad, is the toggle switch that activates or de-activates it. This feature is very helpful since the cursor often gets displaced from its position when your fingers



unknowingly move over the touchpad.

Weighing 3.1 Kgs, the nx9000 comes with a Pentium4 M 2.2 GHz processor, 256 MB of DDR RAM, a 15-inch crisp TFT display, a 40 GB hard disk, and was the only laptop with a combo-drive. Windows XP, Norton Anti-virus and a handsome carry case are the freebies. Apart from an Ethernet and modem connector, it also offers wireless connectivity via an 802.11b wireless card.

It finished second after the ACi Optima in the performance category. In the CPU test, the processor performed well and returned good results. Its memory sub-system lost meekly; while the disk sub-system is the best. The battery lasted for around 3 hours on a normal load—quite good considering the nx9000's power-hungry components.

Priced at Rs 1,00,000, it's certainly expensive, but offers great build-quality, superb features and balanced performance. This laptop won the top honours for its good performance and unmatched feature list.

Price: Rs 1,10,000
+ Superb looks, good performance
- Expensive

HP Compaq nx9000	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶

HP Compaq nx9005

Bridging the divide

The nx9005 was the only laptop in this comparison to ship with an AMD mobile processor.

The keyboard and the touchpad along with the activating and deactivating button, are similar to its Pentium sibling. The touchpad gels with the flat surface to give a neat and clean look. It has the same rugged, solid feel and dimensions as the nx9000.

Configuration-wise, it packs in an AMD Athlon M 2200+ with 256 MB of RAM. A 20 GB hard drive, a CD-ROM drive and the 14-inch display make the laptop more affordable. However, we strongly feel that a 40 GB hard disk should have been provided.

With the exception of the multimedia test, the AMD-powered laptop beat its Pentium counterpart in most of the CPU tests. One area where the nx9005 fared badly was the hard disk subsystem—it just could not keep up with the demand. The high access time and low scores was a clear sign of dated hard disk technology. Knowing that AMD processors are power hungry, the batteries surprised us by supplying power for nearly 3 hours. The laptop also did not show signs of heating up.

Considering its configuration, it is certainly expensive at Rs 70,000, but its sturdy build, good ergonomics and decent performance make up for that.



Price: Rs 70,000
+ Business looks, decent performance
- Lacks features

HP Compaq nx9005	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
Usability	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶